



No Table MANNERS

It has been consistently proved that talks with militants are a futile exercise

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Negotiation was described by someone as the art of getting what you want. But the problem the Government has faced till now is that it rarely knew what exactly it wanted, whether it was in engaging the Hurriyat Conference in Kashmir, the Gorkhas in West Bengal, the ULFA in Assam or the Maoists in Andhra Pradesh. Going on for over a decade, talks with most insurgent and militant groups have either headed nowhere or are dead-locked. The farcical Maoist response to the offer of talks too has failed to impress the government, considering the Andhra Pradesh government's sour experience with the People's War group (PWG) in 2004. Even poet and writer P. Varavara Rao, who

negotiated on behalf of the Maoists, admitted to their using the ceasefire period for regrouping. However, internal security expert Ajai Sahni says the period of ceasefire was also used tactically by the state to penetrate the organisation, which ultimately helped the special anti-Naxal force, Greyhounds, to quell them.

Internal security experts and experienced negotiators believe that for any talks to succeed, there has to be clarity and willingness on both sides. Both need to be clear that the talks are not opportunistic but principled. Also, both need to be sure that they want a solution to the problem. Considering these prerequisites, the situation was not yet ripe for the Centre-Maoist talks. The Maoists were not under enough pressure to come to the negotiating table. Home

Secretary G.K. Pillai said that it will happen only after their top leaders were either arrested or killed.

The Mizoram talks in the early 1980s, often quoted as a success story, came about only after the insurgents were completely broken down. Sahni said that what preceded the Mizo talks was a brutal military campaign. "The insurgents were broken before they came to the negotiating table, and they had little choice," he said. Only after the insurgent group was ready to lay down arms did the government take a generous view, and used talks as a mopping-up operation. Or else, they could be counter-productive and lead to more disruption and violence as in the case of Punjab, where the negotiations became a part of the problem.

The on-off talks with the Hurriyat